In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One

Varṇārhavarṇa Bhagavato Buddhasya Stotra · Toh 1138 · Derge Tengyur
སངས་རྒྱས་བཅོམ་ལྡན་འདས་ལ་བསྟོད་པ་བསྔགས་པར་འོས་པ་བསྔགས་པ

In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, known in Sanskrit as the Varṇārhavarṇa Bhagavato Buddhasya Stotra and in Tibetan as Sangs rgyas bcom ldan 'das la bstod pa bsngags par 'os pa bsngags pa, is a devotional hymn in verse composed by the Indian master Maticitra, better known as Mātṛceṭa, one of the most celebrated poets of early Indian Buddhism. Across thirteen chapters it extols the Buddha from many angles: his omniscience, his powers and fearlessness, the purity and unassailable truth of his speech, his kindness toward beings that can never be repaid, the beauty of his body, and, in its closing chapters, the weariness with existence his passing should arouse and a series of vivid poetic comparisons drawn from nature. The poet opens by confessing that he once squandered his words praising the unworthy, and offers this hymn as a way of washing his speech clean. The work is Toh 1138 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the Praises (stotra) section, and its colophons record a translation by Sarvajñādeva and Paltsek, with a further translation credited to Padmākara and Rinchen Zangpo.

In the language of India: varṇarta varṇa bhagavato buddhāstotra aśākyastava nāma
In the language of Tibet: From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One: the Praise Called Praise of Him Who Cannot Be Praised.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Not knowing what is a worthy field and what is not,
I followed mere sounds,
and so I erred; and in the past
whatever praise I spoke of those not worthy of praise,

that which is soiled by the mud of speech,
O Sage, at the bathing ford from which merit flows,
relying on you, the one who has gone to bliss,
I now begin to wash thoroughly clean.

This is the cleanser that removes
the faults of whatever wrong
I, blinded by delusion,
committed against the supreme assembly.

Until I pass into nirvāṇa,
may I never fall away from the two paths of words:
your own speech,
and the telling of your qualities.

Having made just this talk my very essence,
since I have no other aim than this,
if I speak, may I speak only of this;
or else may I not speak at all.

Your qualities belong to you alone,
and your equal is found only in yourself;
therefore all other qualities
cannot stand in comparison with you.

If one reflects upon
the qualities of a buddha,
all other things that have reached perfection
become like mere impurity.

When there is no one at all like you,
what need is there to speak of one superior?
There is not even anyone
who falls only slightly short of you.

Since there is no example
by which anyone could describe you, Guide,
you have left no opening for example;
homage to you, the Incomparable.

Because the qualities of a buddha are beyond measure,
other persons than you,
even those who have attained a similar liberation,
differ from you very greatly.

Because they are alike merely in being empty,
who, not knowing the difference,
would compare the empty hollow of a hair pore

with the vast sky?

Who could count the countless?
Who could measure the measureless?
Your qualities, in number
and in power, cannot be estimated.

Like one who wanders
within a vast and boundless grove of wish-fulfilling trees,
I, among your good deeds,
am never sated and never find the end.

O ocean of the qualities of those worthy of offerings,
were your qualities as a tathāgata
to be taught in full,
not even the sky could contain them.

The one who served you in your very presence,
the general of the Buddha's Dharma,
the crown of all the hearers,
who proclaimed the profound after you,

when the Blessed One questioned him
on a matter belonging to omniscience,
replied, "I do not know";
thus the profundity of the Buddha's qualities is shown to be beyond even his knowing.

If even those foremost ones
find their powers exhausted before you,
how could a worm of impure existence like me
have any room to conceive of you?

You are a great sāla tree,
whose branches of qualities, bent low by compassion,
this person has merely
taken hold of a little.

When great masses of rain clouds
have let fall their streams of rain,
even if a swallow scorched by the summer heat drinks,
what does it take away?

Though four great rivers
flow down from Lake Anavatapta,
they cannot make it run dry;
what need to speak of other streams that flow from it?

The mines of jewels
are not exhausted by enriching the world;
Protector, the telling of your qualities too
I consider to be just like that.

With diligence, from your own teaching,
I have gathered the flowers of your qualities,
and as a tree with its own blossoms,
I offer flowers to you.

As a mine is honored with its own wealth,
as a mountain with its own pigments,
as sandalwood with its own fragrance,
as a lake with its own water,

as a gold-producing jewel
with the very gold that comes from itself,
so with qualities gathered from your own teaching
I worship you.

From the center of the sky the moonlight spreads in every direction
and all of it comes streaming down;
when the moonlight falling upon the earth opens them,
the groves of kumuda flowers do not fail to bloom.
Just so, in the endless ocean of the Victor's praises,
whose water is his immeasurable qualities,
by speaking even one portion of it, the person of faith
is not left without the fruit he longs for.

The words that speak the Buddha's praise bear fruit:
they are provisions for the journey through births, a path to happiness without obstacle,
they become the sublime vehicle, the water channel for the roots
of qualities such as faith, and much else besides.

Those whose faculties are wholly given over to faith
and who strive in the work of praising the Buddha,

the stream of Dharma that arises for them in each instant
no one but the omniscient can grasp even in part.

Our strength itself is subject to impermanence,
and this leisure and endowment is extremely hard to win;
those who do not strive in this work,
who could be more deceived than they?

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the first chapter, called Praise of Him Who Cannot Be Praised.

Blessed One, when you were present in the world,
I was wholly given over to the power of faith,
because you gazed upon me
with a buddha's eyes moistened by compassion.

Calling to mind
that very compassion of yours,
to you who are worthy of homage
I bow, as though you were before me.

How could anyone who is not omniscient
understand you, the Omniscient One?
Great and vast in your very being,
known by yourself alone, homage to you.

To say of you, "It is this, it is like this,"
is not within the range of one like me;
what you are and what you are like I cannot declare;
homage to one such as you.

Protector, you are like yourself alone;
as the victors are, so are you;
there is no one else at all;
homage to one such as you.

As you know yourself,
as you are known by those like you,
as others do not know you,
homage to one such as you.

As you yourself have made yourself known
through your qualities,

compassion, the ten powers and the rest,
homage to one such as you.

From this day onward,
having gathered the very essence
of the sources of your qualities from those qualities themselves,
as far as I am able, I bow to you.

Homage and reverence to you, the Arhat;
homage and reverence to you, worthy of offerings;
homage and reverence to you, the Wise One;
to you I bow down and pay homage.

The perfect Buddha is a jewel;
the jewel is the very nature of the Dharma;
the Saṅgha is a source of jewels;
to you, the gathering of the three jewels, I bow.

You, worthy of offerings, are a jewel;
the intent of your mind too is a jewel;
you are the source of the jewel of the true Dharma;
to you, a jewel in every way, I bow.

Having become supreme among all jewels,
you outshine every jewel;
to you, the source of all jewels,
the true jewel, I bow.

Homage to you, whose mind is a jewel;
homage to you, whose Dharma is a jewel;
homage to you, a jewel in every respect.

Having made familiar the meditation that ends existence,
you have become supreme among all sages;
to you, the arhat worthy of homage,
I bow with reverence.

You who have taken the way contrary to the world,
who abide at the very limit of reality,
who have reached the culmination of the ascetic's life,
unsurpassed one, homage to you.

Perfect in every aspect,
you outshine all other beauty,
and at all times bring delight;
to you, the lotus among buddhas, I bow.

Of lovely color and sweet fragrance,
beautiful to behold and unhurried,
perfect Buddha, white lotus
in full bloom, homage to you.

You who have thoroughly refined the very essence of bliss,
who have attained every touch you wish for,
the ascetic who brings forth happiness,
ever youthful one, homage to you.

Since your toil has borne its fruit,
you have attained the culmination entire;
ascetic who vowed to speak the sublime,
homage to you.

Relying on pure conduct, you know the Vedas
and all the limbs of the Vedas;
purified by knowledge and conduct,
true brahmin, homage to you.

The noble qualities were never taken from you;
your noble deeds are outstanding;
you carry out the work of the world's teacher;
Noble One, homage to you.

Your mind you made pure
by rightly taking up austerities and vows;
you have washed away all wrongdoing;
you who have bathed, homage to you.

You have attained supreme sovereignty
and outshine all beings;
you sound the lion's roar;
Lion, homage to you.

Leaving a wide and trampled track through speculative talk,
you keep to the high ground of the true Dharma,
the destroyer of all other doctrines;

Great Elephant, homage to you.

The path of the nature of reality is exceedingly hard;
none but you can bear it;
you made it clear and walked it,
and so became the path of the world; homage to you.

Gentle, thoroughly tamed and patient,
endowed with vigor, fine color and strength,
possessing a body complete in all its limbs,
thoroughbred one, homage to you.

You know the directions, the watering places and the pastures;
steady, you have no crooked gait;
you have attained the bull's own place;
Bull among men, homage to you.

Skilled in every means
of taming, free of laziness,
you hold the reins of persons to be tamed;
most excellent one, homage to you.

For if your teaching did not exist,
even the fortunate would find no purpose;
therefore to you, who have become
the pure conduct of all, homage.

Possessing every excellent quality
in utterly complete perfection,
you have brought to an end all striving
after virtuous qualities; homage to you.

Your own aim is completely fulfilled,
and you are wholly intent on the aims of others;
bestower of the nectar of the true Dharma,
you who bring satisfaction, I bow to you.

Afraid of many fears,
you left behind the shore that is not the far shore,
crossed well the great river,
and went to the far shore; I bow to you.

You dispel every disease of the afflictions
and draw out every thorn;
holder of spells, the accomplished one,
chief of physicians, I bow to you.

You know the path that is best and the path that is not,
and show the direction of peace;
caravan leader who brings forth
accomplishment and happiness, homage to you.

You always dispel the darkness,
you always open the eyes,
you always possess the quality of never forgetting;
fully awakened one, I bow to you.

Having surely washed away the mud of stains
with the stainless water of the true Dharma,
you are supremely purified;
utterly pure one, I bow to you.

You have abandoned both wrongdoing and merit;
your being is imbued with emptiness;
toward those who help and those who harm you are even;
utterly free of attachment, I bow to you.

Having surely cleared away all afflictions
and all habitual tendencies, your mind is stainless,
your liberation free of obscuration;
utterly liberated one, I bow to you.

You possess a form one never tires of beholding;
your body is radiantly beautiful with light;
among all things that may be seen
you are the loveliest to see; I bow to you.

Endowed with the thirty-two
major marks of a great being,
together with the host of excellent minor marks,
you who are worthy to be seen, I bow to you.

The unsurpassed qualities of a buddha,
the fearlessnesses, the powers and the rest,
you proclaimed aloud among beings;

you who are worthy of delight, I bow to you.

With the unsurpassed, pure, noble qualities
that are to be cultivated,
both your bodies are imbued;
you who are to be meditated upon, I bow to you.

Because the activities of your body, speech and mind
are thoroughly purified,
you have gone beyond the mere keeping of moral discipline;
you who are pure and clean, I bow to you.

Having abandoned the speech of the afflictions,
intent on the culmination of peaceful action,
you have accepted silence;
Sage at peace, I bow to you.

Your mind is not carried away
by pleasure or by pain; your mind is steady;
you outshine all and have become
the supreme essence of beings; I bow to you.

Toward all, in every way,
your steady understanding and your intentions
are well established, and so you possess
the quality of never forgetting; homage to you.

Rich in qualities beyond the world,
destroyer of the world's distractions,
you who bring light to the world,
Protector of the World, I bow to you.

Even toward friend, enemy and stranger,
intent on the benefit of all beings,
you who are ever loving,
Great Compassion, I bow to you.

Complete in every perception of the Dharma,
Protector endowed with the great superknowledges,
knowing what has been done and what has not been done,
Omniscient One, I bow to you.

Having abandoned every opening for attack,
having cut every bond,
you who make wisdom shine,

dispeller of craving, I bow to you.

Worthy to be pleased, worthy of homage,
not to be transgressed, without fault,
worthy to be worshipped with every effort,
possessor of the three knowledges, I bow to you.

Skilled in removing what does no good,
wholly intent on bringing forth benefit,
devoted single-mindedly to love,
sublime spiritual friend, I bow to you.

For the beings who have entered wrong paths,
you always strive
to turn them toward the sublime path;
sublime kinsman, I bow to you.

Foremost of those who know the true station,
you have attained the supreme station
and become the highest of two-footed beings;
there is no station higher than that.

Having attained the unsurpassed station,
you dispel all suffering;
free of attachment and without grasping,
highest of two-footed beings, I bow to you.

Without relying on your teaching
no one sees reality;
for the world, which is like the blind,
you have become the eye; I bow to you.

If there were no sun upon the earth,
though there were fire and lamps as well,
and though constellations, gems and the moon
were present, the light would not be complete.

Though that light, and others,
and lights far more excellent than that
were present, if you did not abide,

beings would have no light.

Thus for those in the world whose minds
are veiled by the thick cataract
of the black darkness of ignorance, and have grown dim,
you have become the lamp; I bow to you.

Because their understanding of the Dharma is unrefined,
they do not know benefit as benefit,
nor do they know harm as harm;
refinement too comes about by relying on you.

Childish beings for the most part
wish to cast off harm, yet they abandon benefit;
though they seek benefit, they do not know it,
and so they resort to one harm after another.

Because you show them the method,
by relying on you they come to understand
both of these correctly, just as they are;
you have become the physician; I bow to you.

Lord, the one above whom you stand
is himself the highest in the world;
therefore, above even the highest,
to you, the Highest, I bow.

Even those whom the world's wise worship
worship you, the very embodiment of trust;
to be worshipped by those worthy of worship,
sublime one worthy of worship, I bow to you.

Whoever is worthy of praise and is praised,
that person too praises you;
to you, who are to be praised
even by those worthy of praise, I bow.

The gods too bow to you;
the sages too bow to you;
to you, to whom even those worthy of homage
must bow, I bow.

What person with a mind,
paying homage to you, worthy of homage,
an immeasurable field of merit,
would ever be sated?

Therefore I pay homage and bow to you;
to you, worthy of bowing, I bow;
never breaking the stream of homage,
always I pay homage to you.

Ever practicing the sublime conduct, endowed with the path,
knowing what has been done and what has not, and what is attained,
possessed of perfect discernment,
possessor of great offerings, worthy of homage, without equal,
arhat worthy of reverence, homage to you.

Homage to you, who possess an incomparable, delightful body.
Homage to you, who proclaim supremely melodious speech.
Homage to you, who possess a stainless, perfectly pure mind.
Homage to you, whose very being is a cultivated host of qualities.

To bow to the Buddha with the thought that he is a field,
stainless, is something not even a fraction of which
all auspicious things can match, nor all offerings and gifts,
nor austerities and vows, nor all the ritual baths.

To bow to the Lord of Sages
brings renown and makes one glorious;
it tears out all wrongdoing by the roots
and makes one's splendor increase;
it dispels all enemies;
for people in the world
it makes their continuum certain of the happy realms,
and in the end it ripens into the fruit of peace.

Thus, reflecting on its many qualities,
and reflecting too that the body is by nature perishing,
what wise person would undertake
any bodily act other than bowing to the Buddha?

When this teaching, which dispels
the Lord of Death, has faded away,

and everything is covered by darkness,
to whom will one show reverence?
Therefore hasten to perform
worship without equal;
the fears of the future
have already arrived, right now.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the second chapter, called Homage.

Kinsman of the Sun, whose light
is far more luminous than the sun's,
foremost and supreme of all to whom homage is due,
worthy of homage, I pay homage and bow to you.

Of great strength, a great hero,
of great superknowledge and great power,
you who loose great arrows on the field of battle,
with a great festival I worship you.

Worthy of the world's worship, supreme among the worshipful,
worshipped with the worship of the world,
unsurpassed vessel of worship,
you who are worthy of worship, I worship you.

Through worship and knowledge you attained realization;
your mind has not a trace of pride;
to you, who are worthy of honor, I set aside
all prideful thoughts and give you honor.

Even toward those who revere you and those who do not,
you whom the world worships with reverence,
Indra, devoted to honoring you,
reverently pays you honor.

There is no one at all like you;
none superior has arisen, nor ever will;
therefore toward all beings you are
the unequalled one, even toward foe and friend.

Born from the unmixed noble lineage,
equal in fortune to all the buddhas,

with the radiance of your complexion and your wisdom
you were born, illuminating every direction.

Endowed with the thirty-two marks,
with rays of light shining a fathom around,
with the eighty excellent minor marks that accord with the marks,
blazing with splendor,

your body possessing the glory of a great king
outshines the beauty of all;
illuminating the world,
you abide like a second sun.

Blessed One, the dharmas understood in all times,
all the sources of every kind,
like a myrobalan fruit in the palm of the hand,
have become the domain of your mind.

Toward dharmas, the moving and the unmoving,
the one and the manifold, each in its own way,
as the wind moves through space,
your mind meets no obstruction.

Just as for you, who accomplish what is to be done,
by the mere arising of a thought
everything is accomplished as you wish,
so have you fully comprehended the dharmadhātu.

For you, who have reached the culmination of virtue,
there is no virtue born of effort;
whatever you may wish,
it depends on the wishing alone.

The being of dharmas as dharmas,
the nature of reality, and the power of dharmas,
each abiding together with its causes,
together with its conditions and its results,
with their elements and their various divisions,
with their arising and their ceasing, in all their breadth:
all of this, each one, in every aspect,
you, the Omniscient One, know, and no other.

To you even the deeply hidden is manifest;
even the very far is near;
even the most tangled is plain and clear;
even the very high is low;
even the deepest dark is filled with light;
even where great doubt remains, it is evident;
even the most profound of things to be known
lies plain before you.

Just as for great Indra's elephant
a girth made of gold is no burden,
so even the most profound nature of reality
does not weary you.

As freedom from attachment is among dharmas,
as straightness is among the ways of deliverance,
as a buddha is among the excellent,
so you are supreme among all beings.

As the unshakable is among liberations,
as the nature of reality is among reasonings,
as omniscience is among the kinds of wisdom,
so you are supreme among all embodied beings.

As liberation is among purities,
as emptiness is among the truths,
as patience is among austerities,
so you are supreme among all living creatures.

As your body is among forms,
as your mind is among minds,
as your Dharma is among teachings,
so you are supreme among all living creatures.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the third chapter, called The Establishment of Omniscience.

Sugata, you alone,
the one Dharma that illuminates all dharmas,
possess the knowledge of all aspects;
it is yours and no one else's.

By your wisdom alone
all that can be known is pervaded;
for all others besides you,
the knowable alone remains beyond them.

"From this cause and condition comes this result;
from this, that does not come":
all such certainty of what is possible and what is impossible
you know, and no other.

The ripening of actions rightly undertaken,
in all its times,
and all the realizations of every level,
in every aspect you know, and no other.

All the levels of yoga without exception,
the establishment of the afflicted
and of the purified, together with their profound depths,
you alone have fully understood.

Faculties that are keen and faculties that are not,
the lesser, the middling and the great,
with their endless distinctions of every part,
none but you has understood.

Whatever comes into accord
and whatever comes into discord,
all the varied inclinations of people,
you alone have fully understood.

This world has various elements;
all the various elements without exception,
the divisions of the various elements, you alone
know, and no other.

The various accomplishments
that arise from various causes and conditions,
all these, through the power that knows the paths leading everywhere,
you have fully understood.

What has arisen in beginningless existence,
and what will arise without end,
to all this your wisdom

gains entry as if seeing it directly.

The former limit and the later limit,
the coming into being of the world,
and likewise the linking of rebirth,
you see as though they were between the limits.

Whether it be near or far,
just as it is directly evident to you,
so too have you abandoned the obscurations
together with their habitual tendencies.

"This thing is not fully known,
and of this affliction the habitual tendency
still remains": that one cannot say this,
that is the station you have attained.

Whatever you declared to be obstacles
are surely obstacles;
whatever path you have taught,
that alone surely leads to deliverance.

"That cannot obstruct,"
or "That does not lead to deliverance":
not even a fragment of such objection from others
could possibly apply to it.

There is nothing you were to conquer that you have not conquered;
there is nothing knowable you have not brought to light;
you, the Lord, are the one who knows all
and has conquered all, and no other.

Since you possess the powers and are not given to fear,
it is fitting that you are never daunted;
but that, though possessing such might,
you hold no one in contempt, that is a marvel.

That you have freed from their arrogance
some who were full of false pride
was only a means of taming them;
in it there was no pride in your strength.

What in the world is said of the powerful,
that they are "victorious over all,"
is said of others by way of praise;
that station is fully realized in you.

Guide, no one is able
to challenge you in accordance with the Dharma;
you are not one in whom faults may be sought;
you have found the ease of being faultless.

Being without fault, you need not
guard the four from anyone;
because these four are wholly complete,
no one can find an opening against you.

Your understanding is unimpeded toward all;
your attention is ever closely present;
your compassion is equal toward all;
your mind is attached to nothing.

You have crossed the whole ocean of the knowable;
you have abandoned all habitual tendencies for good;
you know the distinctions of every obstacle;
you are skilled in every way of deliverance.

You know the dispositions of all;
you have gone to the far shore of the means of taming;
and in teaching the antidotes to all the various afflictions
you are never daunted.

Those childish talkers who, though relying on you,
have not gained confidence,
that is the fearsome power
of the thicket of the darkness of ignorance.

Whatever, even relying on your word,
has not been removed,
each such thing is called an obscuration,
and those obscurations are not yet exhausted.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the fourth chapter, called Praise of the Powers and Fearlessnesses.

Hearing your word, O Sage,
which tells of the faults of existence, beings grow weary of it;
but though they blaze on every side
in the fire of saṃsāra's unbearable suffering,
beings clad in the armor of unknowing
do not grow weary in that way.

Thus, Protector, your word
makes its meaning utterly clear, even to direct experience;
and since by its explanation the profound
and deep-bottomed nature of reality becomes plain,
your word performs
the miracles of reversal as well.

One does not see the end of its words,
nor can one fathom the depth of its meaning,
yet each follows the other;
what greater wonder could there be than this?

Best of speakers, your word
has a great many synonymous expressions,
yet has no needless repetition,
and its manner of composition is reasoned.

Best of speakers, your word
has the qualities of the four bases,
and though it is the support of the four kinds of answer,
in meaning it never becomes twofold.

In what it permits and what it forbids,
your word is in some cases categorically fixed,
and in some cases not fixed,
yet there is no contradiction between them.

For the sake of the reality of the Dharma,
it is the ground of the station beyond dispute;
through the excellent quality of reasoning
it refutes all false teachings.

It is single-mindedly devoted to the ultimate,
yet is faultless with regard to the conventional as well;
since it does not contradict the two truths,

reason itself arises from your word.

Toward those without afflictions it is wholly gentle;
toward the afflicted, even when it rouses them sternly,
your word has neither
favoritism nor the faults of worldly existence.

Toward what accords with purification
it does not fall into partisanship;
toward the afflictions, which have become the enemy,
your word is never lacking in intolerance.

Even when it holds a hundred words of censure,
it has no fault of casting scorn;
even when it utters words of high praise,
it shows no dependence on anyone.

It has nothing added and nothing left out;
it has both concision and expansion;
when examined, it proves sound;
and from the very beginning it is nothing but good.

Its speech is most melodious, yet does not breed attachment;
it is abundant, yet never without essence;
it is varied, yet its meaning is not confused;
your word holds many marvels.

Lord of speech, your word
captivates the mind, yet has no clinging;
it does no harm to those of majesty;
it is all-pervading, yet the base do not understand it.

It makes the hairs stand on end
and makes the dust rise up on every side;
it makes bodies show their signs
and makes trembling arise;
it fills the world of the gods with weariness
and makes a sound resound everywhere;
it makes even the earth, which rests in stillness,
move in six ways.

It reverses the nature of embodied beings,
habituated from beginningless time,
and places in their hearts
what is not familiar to their nature;
it does not quarrel with them over their own faults,
yet it is as though it pains their minds.

For the wise who enter by way of reasoning,
it is like a rain of nectar falling;
your word, good in the beginning,
good in the middle and good at the end,
when heard, reflected upon and meditated,
becomes nectar for accomplishing it.

When you speak your word in a single utterance
to a great assembly
of many differing inclinations,
it appears as though it were many,
and each one understands, "This
is spoken for my sake alone";
what greater wonder could there be than this?
What greater marvel could there be than this?

You do not abandon the nature of reality,
yet you accord with the world's conventions too;
even while proclaiming them,
you teach the cultivation of the other.

In your word there are affliction and purification;
there are actions, and the results of actions;
there is the activity that goes with them,
yet there is no agent.

When the world with its gods and humans
heard this,
like the moon in water when it trembles,
each one was deeply shaken.

Since the differing things that come to be,
whether as good or as bad,
all depend on conditions,
how could there be any agent at all?

If anything had independence,
it would be an agent; but that is not reasonable.
Therefore, of all dharmas,
you declared that they have no agent.

To the world with its gods
you beat the drum of this Dharma of emptiness
with the lion's roar,
and so you abide, having set its boundary.

Since it has illuminated the world
like the light of the sun,
all other words besides it
have become utterly worthless.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the fifth chapter, called Praise of Perfectly Pure Speech.

All dharmas are without self;
all conditioned things are momentary;
nirvāṇa is peace: these are called
the three characteristics, the seal of the Dharma.

Beyond the reach of every disputant,
unbreakable, you established it.
However things may be spoken of,
what in the world transgresses its own nature?

Though those who cling to their positions
grow practiced in polemic, who
could make that very truth otherwise,
as though making fire itself cold?

Someone might perhaps inflict a wound
upon unobstructed space,
but this seal of the Dharma
cannot rightly be contradicted.

In the word of you who know the nature of reality itself,
there is the teaching of the great black references,
and so this is known to be there;
in other doctrines it is not.

Relying on divergent views,
worldly people fall into dispute;
you alone have realized
the state of the abode free of dispute.

Though the blind may quarrel,
one with eyes who sees forms
does not fall into quarreling:
just that is the simile for you and the childish.

You, who speak in accord with the Dharma,
have no dispute with anyone:
not with the wise, because they speak well;
not with the unwise, because you pay them no heed.

Theses have vanished,
the net of views is utterly destroyed.
When there is no ground for it, why would you,
who have no ground, enter into dispute?

What would a steadfast one like you,
who has won sovereignty, dispute about?
What does the thousand-rayed sun
contend about with darkness?

Like lashing at space with a whip,
disputation cannot overpower you.
Dust thrown against the wind
falls back upon the very one who threw it and clings to him.

Worldly people fall into notions of permanence;
your sphere is reality just as it is.
Therefore you are not alike
with the many who have been inverted.

As with iron and gold,
how could those wrongly attached
ever be set side by side
with you, who are free of attachment?

The childish do not understand
that you, Protector, wish their benefit and happiness;
those who, contrary to that, assail you

bring ruin on themselves by their own doing.

No one hurls himself
into a dense wreath of blazing flame;
so no one should assail
the Victor, the invincible, the radiant one.

Having set a time here to challenge you,
when you in turn set another time,
he could not rise from his seat,
as if bound tight to a stake.

Since in the assembly you broke
the fangs of the debater Satyaka,
the horns of all opposing disputants
are thereby broken as well.

Some opposing disputants,
on meeting you, bow down;
some turn back from far away;
others come before you and lose heart.

Some, because you rained down the true Dharma
in streams of nectar,
through perfect right practice
devote themselves to the true Dharma.

Alas, Protector, lord of compassion!
Alas for delusion, the evil affliction!
Alas, how craving spreads abroad!
Alas, how pride brings ruin!

These three that are not the true Dharma
throw these people into turmoil,
and as if swept off by a fearsome current,
they are parted from your way.

Through these, views, doubt and the other
secondary afflictions, each obstructing the path,
and all that defiles
increase.

As one who has heard the kalaviṅka's song
takes no delight in the cawing of the crow,
so one who has tasted your Dharma
grows no attachment to the words of others.

Even those who, making a show of the Dharma,
entered into your teaching,
hearing it for a base purpose,
find it becomes for them like honey to a camel.

True, easy to understand, and meaningful,
with intent and with wondrous power,
inexhaustible yet concise,
endowed with utterly great power,

supreme in essence, supreme in flavor,
rich in synonyms and rich in method,
fully complete and unmixed,
majestic and renowned:

who, having heard your speech,
endowed with qualities such as these,
would sniff at the words of others, its opposite,
which are like something rotten?

Be it suffering or be it pleasure,
whatever is without benefit
should be entirely abandoned,
and its opposite pursued: so you taught.

Of you, who thus taught the distinction
in pursuing the pleasant and the unpleasant,
how could those who preach the common way
or the way of exhaustion be followers?

That for every practice
you taught the purpose for which it is done,
that itself is the boundary that divides
your word from the words of others.

So great is the difference
between your word and the words of others,
that poison and nectar are not so far apart,

nor even darkness and light.

So wide is the gulf
between your word and the words of others,
that heaven and the lower realms are not so far apart,
nor the sweet juice pressed out and the husk thrown away.

Those have mere words as their essence;
this has both words and their meaning.
By that is explained the difference
between your word and the words of others.

Whatever difference there is
between you, Sugata, and those speakers,
just that is the height and the lowliness
of your word and the words of others.

Just as the gap between existence and liberation
cannot be measured,
so, Hero, the difference between your word
and the words of others is the same.

Whatever separates entering and turning back,
whatever separates defilement and purification,
just that, Hero, is the difference
between your word and the words of others.

Since this is suchness alone,
and that is wholly deceptive in nature,
what other distinction should one seek
between your word and the words of others?

Since this alone is virtuous
and that is wholly an obstacle,
what could be more unlike
than your word and the words of others?

What is tainted and steeped by that
is made pure by this:
just that, Protector, is the difference
between your word and the words of others.

All those blurt out what is not noble;
this alone is well spoken. For that reason
your word and the words of others
are surely the firm and the unfirm.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the sixth chapter, called Praise of Being Free of Dispute.

That which, in its forward course and its turning back,
is the very nature of these beings,
and which the whole world with its gods,
each and every one, cannot pass beyond:
in forward order and in reverse order,
the twelve terms in their two forms,
that, you taught, is worthy of the sun-worship
offered to the sun of the true Dharma.

Since in a single existence of apparitional birth
its links are not complete,
reciting it fourfold for each link in turn,
just as they are, is the threefold worship.

From that same formula with all its links complete,
if one recites the words of twelve syllables
in the manner of the truths, as before,
that is the true going forth.

Those who in your teaching rightly practice
this which is brahma,
those brahmins become brahma:
this is the brahma in harmony with the three secrets.

The holy life and brahma,
the fruit of the holy life and the aim of brahma,
O supreme Brahma, apart from your teaching
are found nowhere else.

Without the holy life
no one becomes a brahmin;
and this straight path, too,
is found in no one else.

One endowed with knowledge and conduct
is brahma, so the brahmins declare;
that knowledge and that conduct
are found nowhere but in your teaching.

That knowledge is the knowledge of the trainee and of the one beyond training;
conduct is what brings its attainment.
Elsewhere, of that path of Dharma,
not even the name is found.

The door to the deathless,
by cultivating which all castes become brahmins,
had long been shut;
you opened it.

How could one gripped
by evil views and doubt become a brahmin?
Apart from your tradition,
none other can cut this knot.

"Brahmins are the sons of Brahmā,
born from his heart and from his mouth":
that saying of the world
has borne its fruit in you.

You are Brahmā; the path of Brahmā is yours;
you are the bull among brahmins;
you are the one who initiates, and the teacher too;
you are the chief priest at the seasonal rites.

A brahmin well taught by you
does not become impure;
a brahmin initiated by you
does not fall from the holy life.

Apart from your teaching, in no one else
is there a Dharma by which one becomes a brahmin;
nor is there the worship of Brahmā,
nor the path of Brahmā,

nor the three truths of Brahmā,
nor the three characteristics of Brahmā,

nor the three supreme things of Brahmā,
nor the lineage of Brahmā.

All the fine sayings
there are in the world come from your teaching;
this faultless expression
belongs uniquely to the Sugata alone.

Whoever besides you
possess speech without fault,
all of them are brahmins of what you,
knower of all dharmas, have well spoken.

Like letters that a worm has eaten into wood,
whatever fine saying is found apart from this,
like gold within iron,
does not befit them.

Like choice sandalwood
set down in a grove of castor-oil trees,
who would believe that it belongs there,
when what comes before and after contradict it?

One who believes that a ripe mango,
tied onto a neem tree,
grew from it,
would perhaps think that others have fine sayings.

As sandalwood comes from Malaya,
so apart from you, in this world with its gods,
there is no source
of the jewels of fine sayings.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the seventh chapter, called Praise of Speech in Harmony with Brahmā.

Rarely, one perhaps in a hundred,
those self-arisen ones like the rhinoceros,
delighting without speaking in what they have realized in their own minds,
go their way in solitary majesty.

Since the paths that lead to ruin are many,
that path to nirvāṇa,

ever a source of great joy,
you opened as a great highway.

Like elephants, delighted youths travel it,
and even women, whose strength and intelligence
are said to be but two fingers' breadth,
have grown practiced in it.

That, O best of the radiant,
is the miracle of relying on you:
the splendor, unique to a buddha,
of power beyond measure.

For those seized in many ways
by the serpents of defilement,
you are the faultless and unrivaled source
of the universal antidote.

For those possessed by desire and the rest,
you, who make the flawed flawless,
also fully taught the Dharma
of meditation on the unattractive and the like.

Since you taught as the Dharma of the path of accumulation
virtues that are still with outflows,
one relies as well on the particular differences
among things, one against another.

Yet since that too is tainted by secondary afflictions,
it is destroyed by the general antidote;
like the stick that stirs a funeral pyre,
these are burned in the fire of wisdom.

Before your awakening
you taught the Dharma that causes the happiness of entering existence;
then, having attained awakening,
you taught the Dharma of the happiness of turning back.

Even after you became a buddha,
it is not that you did not teach those virtuous dharmas with outflows;
for the most part you dedicated them
as causes concordant with nirvāṇa.

What misfortune is there
from which you have not drawn beings out?
And what excellence is there
with which you have not joined the world?

You cut the knot of doubt,
tore out the thorns of evil views,
burned the poisonous creeper of craving,
and destroyed all the poison of anger.

You removed the cataract of ignorance,
toppled the banner of pride,
destroyed the barrenness of mind,
and severed the bonds.

You untied every knot,
and built a ship for the floods;
the great ocean that is the source of the floods
you also dried up.

Faults, dregs and crookedness
that secretly corrupt the mind,
the root of the poisonous tree of defilement,
you pulled out from its base.

You cut off all the evil paths
sought through the inversions,
and swept clean the glorious straight path,
the single way that leads to the deathless.

Others, those to be trained,
you drew out of the eight faults,
and set them in the state of a fine thoroughbred
endowed with the eight desirable qualities.

And having drawn them out of the filthy stream
seething with the worms of defilement,
you let them swim, with limbs unafflicted,
in stainless water.

Having cleansed away the fault of broken discipline,
you anointed them with the unguent of moral discipline,
and covered them with the stainless garments

of conscience and of shame.

Having adorned them
with the splendid white ornaments of the true Dharma,
you seated them upon the great
lion throne of meditative concentration.

You strewed over them the flowers of the limbs of awakening,
undefiled and sweetly fragrant,
and with joy in the Dharma, the noble flavor
free of material things, you satisfied them.

Having brought them out of the beginningless slavery
to existence, so full of harm,
your own children, for all time,

you made them, never to fall away.
Others you made vessels
of solitary buddhahood in a time to come;
others still you empowered
as supreme regents of the Great Vehicle.

Knowing the words of all dharmas,
skilled in the ground of every meaning,
knowing every distinction of language,
endowed with eloquence in every direction,

proclaiming, "I have become the friend
of you who have no protector,"
you remain as though embracing
all beings with great compassion.

A Teacher possessed of great compassion,
loving and acting in love,
diligent in that and free of laziness:
who else is there like you?

You are the protector of all sentient beings,
the good kinsman common to all;
since people do not know you are here as their protector,
for that reason they sink.

The qualities of friendship,
by rightly taking up which
even the lowest can be a friend,
none but you understands.

All the outer supports and strengths
you have brought to perfection;
but since their inner strengths are incomplete,
the childish undergo suffering.

When one considers that the world is without right conduct,
that the nature of reality is profound,
that beings are inclined to what is lesser,
that evil paths are many,
that busyness, habitual since beginningless time,
arises of its own accord,
and that meditation is hard to attain
even with great effort,
then, had there not arisen in the world
an excellent kinsman like you,
who clearly shows the way
of rightly taking up the white dharmas,
all beings would be plunged in darkness,
and, wretched from the unwanted feelings that arise,
crying out loud laments,
they would become nothing but the very nature of the lower realms.

However beings may stand toward you,
in any of three ways, let others deal with them accordingly;
to enemy, friend and stranger alike
you play the part of the best of friends.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the eighth chapter, called Praise of Bringing Benefit.

The quality of sharing
is complete in you alone;
to bring benefit to others,
other people must come together in a host.

Those of your disciples
who are skilled in the ways of gathering disciples,

since they too are not perfectly skilled,
follow only a portion of you.

Blessed One, your sharing
of material things extends even to your life;
your sharing of the true Dharma
is free of the teacher's closed fist.

You are the unsurpassed doer
of the work of sharing;
possessing every excellence in full,
you are not one to be forsaken.

Most beings are cruel
and delight in doing harm to others;
but you, against the nature of the world,
go in the direction opposed to its current.

Those who repay what was done for them are few;
those who give benefit are only some,
and most of them with expectation;
you alone are of pure character.

You are not moved to act by benefit received,
nor turned back by harm inflicted;
thinking, "They have the fortune for it,"
you engage with all beings equally.

At night the kumuda flower
opens and the lotus closes;
by day the lotus opens
and the other closes;
and yet the light of the sun and moon
does not fall on one side.
Just that is the simile for how you teach
the childish and the wise.

Since, Protector, all that you do
is solely for the sake of others,
how could you, who give benefit beyond measure,
ever be repaid?

You have no activity at all
that does not make beings flourish;
even your merest breath
brings benefit and happiness to beings.

The fragrance of the Buddha's breath,
which overpowers every scent:
when they smell it, even those who were hostile
come to have faith in you.

When the fragrance of the Buddha's breath descends,
even the heedless gods
abandon their divine realm
and turn toward the discipline.

From hearing the true Dharma from you,
no one knows satiety;
therefore, in the ultimate sense,
you alone satisfy and fulfill.

Like rain for living creatures,
you are the nourishment of all the wise;
the nourishment that comes from you
has no equal anywhere.

How kindly you intend
even toward those who wish to kill you,
the childish, whose minds are untrained,
are unable to believe.

What good you bring about
even for those who hate you:
that stage has passed beyond
the reach even of what the mind can wish.

Some who have realized the supreme flavor
of your bestowing benefit
are kinsmen who come to enjoy
their share of your Dharma.

If these sentient beings knew
the compassionate intention you possess,
then, living by your teaching,

they would enter even a blazing fire.

But because, struck by the enemy Māra,
they do not realize it,
the childish who act against your teaching
destroy themselves.

Those who turn from your teaching to others,
experiencing the darkness of the great abyss
and burning torment,
alas, will wander for a long time.

People who do not turn to your Dharma,
blinded by delusion,
even after reaching the peak of existence,
bring about existence in which suffering arises again.

Those who follow your teaching,
even without attaining actual meditative concentration,
as though binding a cloth over Māra's eyes,
turn back existence.

First you laid low
the flower banner of Māra the son of the gods;
then you cast down the lofty banner of pride
of the Māra of the afflictions.

Before you attained awakening,
you conquered the lord of the desire realm;
on the uninterrupted path to awakening
you conquered the lord of the three realms.

Lord, you are in this world
the bravest among heroes;
who would count as foremost in bravery
people under the sway of the afflictions?

Since you destroyed the army of the afflictions
in the mindstreams of both yourself and others,
there is no supreme hero other than you,
and no other victor in fierce battle.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the ninth chapter, called Praise of What Cannot Be Repaid.

The qualities of your eyes, deep blue,
with their white and black set clearly apart,
are not rivaled by the qualities
of the world, its chiefs included.

Your upper lip is unsurpassed in splendor,
and the lower is splendid too; both of them
possess an unsurpassed perfection
of the elements and of what derives from the elements.

Were either of them lacking,
there would be no matching pair at all;
so the upper one rests above the other,
and the lower serves as the other's base.

Your lips, the seat of splendor,
so fitted to one another:
how wonderful, so finely joined as a pair!
How wonderful, unsurpassed in their accord!

When you teach they move,
yet in their clarity there is no wavering,
and from within a little appears
of the splendor of the risen moon of your teeth.

They scatter like flowers the sounds
that come forth from their place,
and help those whom others have brought near
along the path that they travel.

Beside the blazing splendor
of these lips, like the glow of molten copper,
the bimba fruit, the twilight clouds
and the lovely red lotus are like corpses.

Those who see your lips
moving in their beauty
have truly found their eyes;
for them, seeing too has borne its fruit.

Protector, not a string of pearls,
not a garland of jasmine and kumuda,
not the body of the snowy mountains' ridge
bathed in the light of the moon,
not a line of white birds
gracing the autumn rivers,
not the new autumn moon
shining in a cloudless sky:
none of these, O Tamed One, dares to rival
even in part this bright white string of your teeth,
any more than lamplight
rivals the light of the sun.

This row of vajra shoots,
moistened and steeped
with the nectar-flavor of the noble Dharma:
what thing could ever be its like?

The kumuda, the moon, the jasmine and the rest,
the four standard examples of whiteness,
once your row of teeth appeared,
seem to have lost their place.

Since this has appeared in the world,
all things without exception
that are white and beautiful
have come to seem as though stained.

These teeth, finely set
between your tongue and your lips,
are beautiful as liberation is
between realization and peace.

Seeing that this world is outshone
by the splendor of your row of teeth,
your eyeteeth stand raised like banners,
as if to say, "We have won!"

Your eyeteeth, even and rounded,
beautiful, with sharp white tips,
having overpowered every comparison,
remain as though ablaze.

The crescent moon in the world
shines crooked;
your eyeteeth, which do not bend
and are lovely in form, have made it so.

With your eyeteeth for its crescent phase,
your fine face for its full moon,
encircled by a tawny glow,
outshining all with your fathom-wide light,
O moon among sages, by the perfect
qualities of your form
you make all the perfect qualities of the moon
wane in every phase.

Sugata, on your body,
like the heart of a golden lotus,
the body hairs, curling to the right, one to each pore,
soft and stainless, grow upward.

Glossy, untangled and unruffled,
like the luster of sapphire,
they seem adorned as though with a fine inlay
of blue jewels.

O elephant among men, that mark of yours,
hidden like a great elephant's,
wholly untouched
by stains within or without,
that member of yours, like an ornament,
that lovely member, is excellent,
rounded as though
cast from unalloyed gold.

It remains outshining
the fine male parts of all the chief
thoroughbreds,
beautiful in their own shapes.

Protector, because you abide in the holy life,
and because its shape is so very beautiful,
you keep it concealed,

and yet it is not something that needs concealing.

That out of compassion, to those in doubt,
you showed that mark by other means,
many, many times,
like the moon's form glimpsed through a gap in the clouds,

moving, as it were, the unmoving
mountain of conscience and shame,
and making it, through the eye of great compassion,
an object of their understanding:

The cluster of filaments of a lotus
slowly unfolding, just a little open,
Protector of beautiful limbs,
does not approach that beauty of yours.

Although the glorious full moon
is round,
it still does not suffice as the ground of a simile
for your head, the supreme limb.

On the path of beauty, created
by the karma of hundreds of vast merits,
could anything projected by another intention,
even should it come, ever catch up?

Though it is fully covered by its own sheath,
by your robes, and by restraint,
it is as if made manifest
by your other perfect marks.

To that supreme limb of yours,
you who possess noble limbs,
I offer worship with bowed head, with a mind full of faith,
and with my speech as well.

Supreme among those who inspire faith,
you whom no one tires of beholding:
if anyone feels anger toward you,
that is black darkness, the lowest and most wretched.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the tenth chapter, called Praise of a Part of the Body.

Since the inclinations of sentient beings
accord with their dispositions,
for now my own thought
has grown wide with faith toward your broad tongue.

Who would not honor your broad tongue
with head, with mind and with speech?
It is the mother of all these scriptures,
the maker of jewels.

To me, Lord, among
all your unsurpassed deeds,
this broad tongue
appears the unsurpassed summit.

Because it performs the Dharma activity
of proclaiming the teaching to beings,
like a king it stands
as chief among all the marks.

When, to cut the doubts of others,
it is drawn forth from your mouth,
like a mass of autumn twilight clouds
it covers the moon of your face.

That one so broad and beautiful
should rest without crowding
within a mouth filled with teeth:
what could be more wondrous than that?

That, surely, is the power
of the utter softness
and pliancy of that excellent one
whose might is beyond measure.

When your mouth roars like thunder,
it makes it shine like refined gold of the Jambu river,
like the glow of molten copper,
like a flickering garland of lightning.

Having won, as it were, the kingdom
of excellent and perfect training,
it plays and moves at ease
from your mouth into other places.

Those faultless flowers of speech,
whose sweet fragrance makes people proclaim,
"He speaks flowers,"
this tongue scatters abroad.

For that very reason, Victor, from you
comes speech supremely sweet;
and because of its most sweet fragrance
you are widely renowned as "the One of Sweet Speech."

The instruction and the guidance
by whose power one like you
is famed as the giver of nectar
depend upon this very tongue.

The turning of the wheel of Dharma
in the world with its gods,
heedless of your own weariness,
was done by this virtuous one.

That this world was lit up,
filled with hundreds of fine sayings
as though strewn with jewels,
is the power of this tongue.

Declaring what is fitting and what should be done,
it is the noble one that speaks all dharmas;
like a branch of the wish-fulfilling tree,
it bestows fruits of every kind of jewel.

Without the broad tongue, who in the world
would bear the burden of the eloquence
that comes with omniscience,
the eloquence of the analytical knowledges?

Whatever Dharma you considered
and then explained to someone,
this tongue, without any sluggishness,

strings into a garland like flowers.

If this had not taught it,
who would know that you are omniscient?
Who would know that you possess great compassion,
or know your other qualities?

Were there no teaching,
a sage like you would not become manifest;
and the teaching depends on the broad tongue
as accomplishment depends on scripture.

Though it speaks the Dharma in various ways
and tastes various flavors,
it is not stained by attachment to flavor,
just as space is not stained by mud.

It accords with abiding in silence,
and in speaking too it has no fault;
toward both these opposed states
it is in perfect accord.

When abiding in silence it takes no delight in that;
when teaching it never wearies;
it is the virtue of discernment itself,
and engages evenly in all.

Thus in all its speaking it is human,
yet it proclaims nothing but dharmas;
wondrous is its entry into conduct,
wondrous too its devotion to reason.

Through merit born of the elements
and through its nature of speaking the Dharma,
it is always perfumed
with the twofold fragrance of a buddha.

As a pure object for the eye
and by its nature sweet with merit,
it is widely renowned
for sweetness of both kinds.

Those who have seen this flawless one
drawn forth from your mouth
are people who have eyes,
and those eyes of theirs are glorious.

Those who with the cups of their ears
have directly drunk its sweet speech
like a stream of nectar,
those wise ones are glorious indeed.

As though it adorned sounds,
as though by sound it adorned the lands,
when you explain the Dharma, your mouth
is as though wholly concealed.

By its own beautiful qualities,
your moon face, O Sage,
already the ornament of the world,
appears an ornament still greater.

In color, in shape, in sweet speech,
and in the power of its utter softness,
no material thing
like the broad tongue have I ever seen.

If the goddess Sarasvatī
had any bodily form,
this broad tongue, whose every part is flawless,
would surely be she.

When the broad tongue sets about
beating the drum of Dharma everywhere,
all the sounds of gods and humans
lose their flavor.

You, the Teacher, this tongue,
and this unsurpassed word
are the supreme medicine of three ingredients
that destroys every poison of the afflictions.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the eleventh chapter, called Praise of the Tongue.

No field like you
exists in the three worlds;
you are the best of all who are worthy of gifts,
the pure one who purifies the row of guests.

As with space, the waters and the fields,
which have no end,
so the ripening of help or harm
done to you has no end.

If even those who stay neutral toward you
are for now ruined,
tainted by darkness beyond measure,
what need to speak of people who act wrongly toward you?

Just as no end is seen
to the flourishing of any deed
done rightly toward you,
the unsurpassed field of offerings,
so the deed of wrongly opposing you,
who have reached the end of right practice,
likewise has no end
to its decline.

Since impermanence, that vile thing
which knows no bounds,
did not in any way spare
even you, the Mighty One,
alas, how evil is the nature of saṃsāra!
Oh, how peaceful is nirvāṇa,
since even one like you, the embodiment of compassion,
who was here among us, has gone there!

You spoke of the dangers to come,
you explained the way of the Dharma,
and you brought the fourfold assembly
to attain fearlessness.

To guard this excellent path
you appointed those of trained understanding,
Mahākāśyapa, Ānanda,
and others besides;

yet when you, the sole eye of the world,
the stainless one, have closed,
though there is light, this world
is as if covered in darkness.

Sugata, this word of the Sugata
remains, and your children,
the best of children, trainees
and those beyond training, remain as well;
but when you, protector of beings, are no longer here,
like a sky marked by bright planets and stars
yet empty of the moon,
it is sorely bereft.

When you are no longer here, this scripture,
like the splendor of a lake whose nāga has departed,
which before long perishes,
is parted from its fitting essence;
the radiance of its qualities shines no more,
and since other rites and other systems
have torn it and wounded it,
the majesty of its body too is about to fade.

When one considers that the buddhas,
crowned with sovereignty, have passed into final nirvāṇa,
who would not fear existence,
which is like a blazing sword?

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the twelfth chapter, called Praise Arousing Weariness with Existence.

In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, composed by the master Maticitra, is complete.

It was translated, edited and finalized by the Indian preceptor Sarvajñādeva and the chief editor-translator Bandé Paltsek Rakṣita.

Great is the fortune of composing poetry:
relying on you, my understanding,
small as it is, swells greatly,
like a river in the rainy season.

Having gained the human state, so hard to gain,
and having gained this tongue as well,
who would not do himself good
by proclaiming the Protector's qualities?

Your body, adorned with the major marks,
beautiful, a nectar for the eyes,
is like the cloudless autumn sky
adorned with hosts of stars.

The Sage, golden in hue,
beautiful, clothed in Dharma robes,
is like the summit of a golden mountain
wreathed in twilight clouds.

Protector, though you wear no ornaments,
the radiance of your face's round maṇḍala
is not found even in the full moon's maṇḍala
when it is free of clouds.

Your lotus face
and a lotus opened by the sun:
when a bee sees them, over the lotus
it falls into doubt and deliberation.

Your white teeth, beautiful
in your golden-hued face,
are like the stainless autumn moonbeams
entering the clefts of a golden mountain.

You who are worthy of offerings, your right hand
is beautiful with the mark of the wheel;
with that hand you give comfort
to people terrified of saṃsāra.

Sage, when you walk,
your two feet, like lotuses of glory,
print this ground,
and how beautiful it is, as if strewn with lotuses!

Your gait is without equal:
you walk more steadily than the finest elephant in rut,
than a goose beside its mate,

or than the bull that leads the herd.

With the mass of moral discipline as your great body,
beautifully adorned with the trees of meditative concentration,
and pervaded by streams of wisdom,
you are a snow mountain that moves.

Ocean of qualities, whoever
touches you with their body,
you make each one a sacred ford
worshipped by gods and humans.

Your dwelling is a field of accomplishment;
since seeing it purifies the mind,
what need have the wise who long for purity
of Kurukṣetra?

Endowed with the six perfections,
you are truly beautiful,
like the full moon
adorned by the Pleiades.

The lotuses of beings to be trained,
asleep, you awaken,
like the rising sun
making lotuses unfold.

To those gripped by the poison of the afflictions
you give the medicine of wisdom,
like the protector of beings who draws out the venom
of one seized by a fanged serpent.

The fire of your wisdom, like a forest fire,
has burned up the net of views,
as a forest fire, blazing fiercely,
burns up the tender shoots of trees.

Sage, sun whose very nature is blazing wisdom,
you dry up the mire
whose nature is the afflictions;
in this you are like the light of the sun.

Your speech turns the minds of people back
from what should not be done,
like a great herdsman with his rope
turning back cattle gone astray.

Even had you alone, as one might hope,
been freed from the bonds of the afflictions,
yet because you free others as well,
you have become all the more worthy of worship.

With the light rays of your speech
you refresh those tormented by the afflictions,
just as the moonbeams at night refresh
those tormented by the heat of the hot season.

Beings to be trained, parched with thirst for the Dharma,
gaze upon your face
as the cātaka bird, tormented by thirst,
gazes at the massed rain clouds of summer.

With the sound of Dharma in your speech
you bring delight to all who are to be trained,
as at the sound of a sweet song
even roaming deer stand still.

Those who seek refuge yet do not come for refuge
to you who are worthy of refuge,
but go for refuge to the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
will suffer long without a refuge.

That reality which Śakra (Indra)
did not see even with his thousand eyes,
you see with the eye of wisdom
and teach to others as well.

The many disputants,
proud in thinking, "I know the treatises,"
are daunted by your gaze
and circle about like bees.

When with but a single word of yours
you defeat your opponents,
the others keep to silence,

like cuckoos in winter.

The trees that are your good disciples,
their flowers of virtue in fullest bloom,
are beautiful like the trees of spring
adorned with blossoms.

Sage, the arrow of your intellect
has pierced the target of all that can be known,
which the king of archers in the City of Delight
had never pierced before.

The arrogant, proud of their learning,
not knowing your path to liberation,
wander in the wilderness of existence
like a band of blind men in an empty waste.

Worldly people come to doubt
whether the fruits of karma exist or not;
this body of yours has become
the witness to virtuous karma.

Ocean of qualities, I cannot fathom
the final limit of your qualities,
just as a bird cannot reach the end
of the sky, blue as beryl.

From In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, this is the thirteenth chapter, called Praise by Way of Examples.

In Praise of the Praiseworthy, a Praise of the Buddha, the Blessed One, composed by the master Maticitra, is complete.

It was translated by the Indian preceptor Padmākara and the translator, the monk Rinchen Zangpo.

Translator's Notes

• In the verse on the hair pore, the text reads □□□□□□, which makes no sense here; I have read □□□□□□, "empty," which the image of the hair pore and the sky plainly requires. The general of the Buddha's Dharma who answered "I do not know" is Śāriputra, the Dharmasenāpati, though the text does not name him. In the verse on the fruits of praise, □□□□□□□ is obscure; I have taken it as an irrigating channel for the roots, which suits the image but is uncertain. In the second chapter, □□□□□□□ ("cannot declare") is unusual; the sense of the verse is clear.

• The line rendered "you who have taken the way contrary to the world" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is terse and its exact sense is uncertain. In the elephant verse the first line (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is obscure; the rendering "a wide and trampled track through speculative talk" is tentative. Here □□□□□, in a series of epithets alongside ascetic, noble one and bather, stands for brāhmaṇa, the true brahmin, rather than the god Brahmā. Several epithets echo the standard formula of the Buddha's qualities: knowledge and conduct (vidyācaraṇa), guide of persons to be tamed (puruṣadamyasārathi), thoroughbred (ājāneya), bull (ṛṣabha). The final verse continues into the next piece.
• The opening line (□□□□□□□□□□□□□) completes the last verse of the previous piece; □□□ is read in the sense of □□□, "dispel," since "illuminating craving" does not fit an epithet of praise. The "Indra" of the verse on reverence renders □□□□□□, "the lord," which in such contexts usually means Indra, lord of the gods; it might also be read more generally as "the mighty." In the verse rendered "even toward foe and friend," the text's □□□□□□□ is unusual; the sense of impartiality is clear but the exact wording uncertain. In the verse on giving honor, □□□□ is taken as a form of "honor, respect." "Kinsman of the Sun" renders the Buddha's epithet Ādityabandhu.
• The fourth chapter follows the traditional ten powers of a tathāgata (knowledge of the possible and impossible, of the ripening of actions, of the meditative levels, of faculties, of inclinations, of elements, of the paths leading everywhere, of former lives, of death and rebirth, and of the exhaustion of defilements) and then the four fearlessnesses. "The four" that need no guarding are the four things a tathāgata need not guard (his conduct of body, speech, mind and livelihood being already faultless). The verse on the former and later limits is terse; "as though they were between the limits" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ literally. In the verse on doubt, □□□ is taken as "evident." The phrase rendered "gained confidence" (□□□□□□□□) is uncertain.
• "The four kinds of answer" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□) are the four ways of answering a question: categorically, by analysis, by counter-question, and by setting the question aside. "The four bases" (□□□□□□□□□□) is not certainly identified. "The miracles of reversal" renders □□□□□□□□□ literally and is uncertain; it may refer to the Buddha's teaching that turns beings around, the miracle of instruction. In the verse on the afflicted, □□□□□□□□ is taken as "favoritism" (currying favor), and □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ as "the faults of worldly existence"; both are tentative. In the verse on the earth's six movements, "makes bodies show their signs" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) and "makes the dust rise" are literal renderings of obscure lines.
• "The great black references" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□ here not as the deity Mahākāla but as the mahākālāpadeśa, the "great black" criteria (paired with the mahāpadeśa, the great references) by which counterfeit teaching is distinguished from the Buddha's word; the verse claims such tests of authenticity exist only in the Buddha's teaching. The line rendered "those who cling to their positions" (□□□□□□□□□□) is uncertain. In the verse on the thousand-rayed sun, □□ appears to be a scribal slip and is passed over. The sense of □□□□ / □□□□□ as "assail, challenge" is inferred from context. Satyaka (literally "son of the truth-speaker") is taken to be the Jain debater defeated by the Buddha in the assembly at Vaiśālī. In "Through these, views, doubt...", □□□ is read as a slip for □□. "Like honey to a camel" is a literal rendering whose intended point is unclear. "The common way or the way of exhaustion" (□□□□□□□□□□□□) is understood as the two extremes of indulgence and self-mortification.
• The opening verses of the seventh chapter map Brahmanical rites onto the Buddha's teaching: the twelve links of dependent origination, recited in forward and reverse order, take the place of the sun-worship (the Sāvitrī recitation), and their recitation link by link stands for the threefold daily worship. Their exact technical sense (the "two forms," the "fourfold" recitation, the "twelve syllables," "the three secrets," and the triads of Brahmā's truths,

characteristics and supreme things) is obscure, and the renderings are literal. Throughout the chapter □□□□□ is rendered "brahma" where it means the holy or the sacred, and "Brahmā" where the god or the Brahmanical tradition is meant; □□□□□□□□□□□ is "the holy life" (brahmacarya). In "that knowledge and that conduct," □□□ is read as a slip for □□□ ("knowledge"). In the verse on the path to nirvāṇa, □□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□ ("ever"). □□ ("swept clean") is read as □□□ / □□□. "Two fingers' breadth" reflects a proverbial Indian disparagement of women's intelligence; the verse uses it to stress that even they master the path. The simile of the stick that stirs a funeral pyre, which is finally thrown into the fire too, describes how virtues with outflows are used and then consumed by wisdom. The eight faults and eight qualities belong to a simile of training horses. The final lines continue into the next piece.

• The first line completes the sentence begun at the end of the previous piece. The verse beginning "However beings may stand toward you" is obscure; the rendering takes "three ways" as enemy, friend and stranger, named in the next lines. In the first verse of the ninth chapter, □□□□ is read as "come together in a host," meaning that it takes many people together to match the Buddha's generosity; this is uncertain. "You are not one to be forsaken" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is also uncertain. In "When the fragrance of the Buddha's breath descends," □□ is read as a slip for □□ ("fragrance"). The verses on Māra distinguish Māra the son of the gods (devaputramāra) and the Māra of the afflictions (kleśamāra).

• In the first verse, □□□□□□□ is unclear and is rendered loosely as "set clearly apart." The tenth chapter praises the Buddha's physical marks in sequence (eyes, lips, teeth, eyeteeth, body hair, the sheathed private part, and the head); the verses on the sheathed member, one of the thirty-two marks, allude to the story of the Buddha showing it by miraculous means to brahmins who doubted he had all the marks. The verse on the crescent moon is obscure, and the rendering that the eyeteeth have put the moon's crookedness to shame is interpretive. "The supreme limb" is the standard Indian term for the head. In the eleventh chapter, the broad tongue that covers the face is likewise one of the marks, shown to resolve doubts.

• The verse beginning "As though it adorned sounds" is obscure, and the rendering is literal. "Purifies the row of guests" reflects the Indian notion of the paṅktipāvana, the worthy guest whose presence sanctifies everyone seated in a row at a meal. In the verse about the sky empty of the moon, the last line (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is uncertain. The author's name is spelled Maticitra here, a name traditionally identified with Mātṛceṭa. The colophon list of chapters names a thirteenth chapter, but the text as given here closes after the twelfth.

• The opening sentence is the translators' colophon to the first twelve chapters; the thirteenth chapter and the second colophon (Padmākara and Rinchen Zangpo) follow. The "ill-famed field" (sgra ngan zhing) is taken as Kurukṣetra, the Indian pilgrimage site sought for purification, since sgra ngan / sgra mi snyan renders Kuru; this identification is probable rather than certain. The "protector of beings" ('gro skyob) who removes snake venom is likely a poison-healer (jāṅgulika) and is translated literally. The "City of Delight" (dga' byed grong) and its "king of archers" could not be identified with confidence and are translated literally.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the

Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.